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 EDU 498

Mini Unit: [*Long Way Down* by Jason Reynolds & Illustrated by Danika Novgordoff](#):
 Pages 1-47, **week 1 of 2** Mini Unit (first half of the novel).

Audience	Unit Time Allotment	Essential Question
- 11th Grade ELA - in-person class - Heterogenous - Strong Black and Brown student body, especially African American and Latinx - Some ELL's	- 3 classes (MWF) - 80 minute block periods - 10 minutes of journaling at the beginning, leaving 70 minutes of instructional, discussion, and activity time daily	<i>How do our choices shape our identities, and what role does storytelling play in breaking cycles of violence and reclaiming joy?</i>

Daily Materials & Expectations

Pre-unit expectations: Students will have read up to floor 5 in Long Way Down (p47), and will have added sticky notes to mark illustrations or text that stood out to them.

- Students will have their novels annotated to their liking.
- Students will have a laptop with access to canvas, google classroom, etc.
- Students will know where to find the journaling prompts, and begin working on their entry journal when they arrive or as class starts. Ideally, journaling would be a common practice, or at least introduced the week before, so this will not require much instruction or explanation.

Unit Schedule

Monday: Street Code, Revenge, “The Rules”

Objectives: Short Term

- Students will remember the basic plot and characters in LWD
- Students will understand and apply concepts from LWD to street code
- Students will apply, analyze, and evaluate connections between the rules in LWD, street code, and their own experiences
- Students will create various written responses to these connections to deepen their understanding

Objectives: Long Term

- Students will expand upon their criticality on how rules and various social norms affect communities
- Students will expand upon their intellect on how marginalized communities often adopt rules of their own
- Students will practice reflecting upon their own identity to deepen understanding of texts and the real world

Monday: Street Code, Revenge, “The Rules”	
	- Students will engage in a <u>joyful</u> literacy by sharing about themselves and expressing things that are meaningful to them
Materials - White board, dry erase markers - Projector - Copy of LWD - Links to respective content to be viewed and discussed in class - Headphones & laptops for students Time Allotments - Journal 10 mins - Quick timeline/summary on the white board with students help 15 mins - Street Code video 25 mins - Reflect upon and discuss rules/codes/revenge 30 mins	Learning Standards - 11-12R1: Cite strong and thorough textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly/implicitly and make logical inferences, including determining where the text is ambiguous; develop questions for deeper understanding and for further exploration. (RI&RL) - 11-12SL1: Initiate and participate effectively in a range of collaborative discussions with diverse partners on complex topics, texts and issues; express ideas clearly and persuasively, and build on those of others. - 11-12W2c: Use precise language, content-specific vocabulary and literary techniques to express the appropriate complexity of a topic.

Lesson Instruction
Phase 1. <u>Journaling & reflecting.</u> As students arrive, guide them to begin their journaling for <u>10 minutes</u>. Make sure the students are happy with their entry before moving on, this should not be a rushed activity. Please respond to the prompt in the form of a paragraph (5 sentences or more). This is meant to be done in the style of a journal entry meaning: You DO NOT need to use formal, academic language! Say what comes to your mind the way YOU want to say it. I do not care if you use profanity, I do not care if you use slang or the type of wording you would use on a text message/social media comment. I do not care if you don’t address every question, the prompt is meant to get you thinking about the text. I do care to hear what you’re thinking. <i>*Adopted from “The Elevated Educators BLM Journaling” (2020)</i> PROMPT #1 Write about how you found the first half of Long Way Down. Did you like or dislike it? Did you meet any challenges along the way? Did it spark any notable thoughts or feelings? Do you have any questions, predictions, criticisms, or comments?

Available Idea Starters and Frames:

- Something I liked/disliked about the novel is_____
- While reading the novel, I struggled with/didn't understand_____
- The novel made me feel_____
- I think that_____[will happen]
- I wonder_____

Phase 2. Summarizing what was read.

Get the attention of the students and begin making a collaborative timeline & summary on the white board, or on a document (somewhere it can be saved and referred back to for the week, for you AND students). You will want to be sure to get things down like the important characters we come across, and a pretty basic overview of the major plot points and character actions. Additionally, work on a list of terms to refer to such as “snitching”, you should add to this all week so students can refer back to it. This shouldn't take up more time than **15 minutes**, and students should be referring to their copies of the novel.

Start by asking generally what the student's remember, but here are some guiding questions if needed:

- In the first few pages of the Novel, we are introduced to some important characters. Who is the main character? . . . Who else is important? . . . What happens [to Will/Shawn/His Mom]?
- What does Will tell us early on about his life and community? [the Rules, why Riggs killed Shawn, justifications]
- Who does he meet on floor 7? What is their story?
- Who does he meet on floor 6? What is their story?

You can end this timeline by asking if anyone had some questions, comments, or predictions they wrote down in their journal that they want to share and refer back to throughout the unit(s).

Phase 3. Video on street code.

First, play the video once for the whole class. Then, Go over the questions relating to the video. You can answer question 1 with the whole class, asking for help from students. After that, You can give the students another 15 minutes to answer the questions on their own and replay the video on their personal laptops as needed. This should take about **25 minutes**. Put emphasis on “the rules” in LWD before playing the following video.

Reminder of the rules: No crying, no snitching, revenge.

 **Street Codes -- Code of the Street, Elijah Anderson**

Post the questions and video, to be turned in on the shared online space that your class uses to turn in assignments.

1. What kind of life are the people in this video living? What do they do, and what are some of their own moral codes or “rules” they live by? Cite specific things you saw or heard.
2. What similarities or differences do you see with street code and “the rules” in LWD? Cite specific things you saw, heard, or read.

3. Bilal, the community activist, says; “If you’re a man and you feel no hope, or you sense no future; you become destroyed as a person. Then you don’t care what happens to you.”. How might that affect the way Will and other people in his community live? Additionally, how might that perpetuate “the rules”?

Phase 4. Student’s experiences with rules & revenge. 30 minutes

4a. First, ask students to free-write for 10 minutes about either a time they took revenge, or a rule/code that is held dearly in their community. **Make sure to add **that this is a safe space**, and refer to class rules to assure everyone that their stories will be treated delicately and with respect. Also remind students that no one has to share, but it is best to write about something they are comfortable sharing.*

Put the following prompts on the board & In the shared online space that your class uses to turn in assignments:

Prompt #1. Considering the rules in LWD, and the video we just watched on street code, think of one or more rules/codes that you or other people always follow just because everyone in your community follows it. Explain why you do or don’t follow it.

Prompt #2. Think about Will, and why he wants to get revenge for his brother. Has there ever been a time where you wanted to, or did indeed get revenge on someone. Why did you do this? Was it for you, or for someone else? Was it worth it?

Alternative Prompt #3. If you don’t feel comfortable reflecting on your personal experiences, make up your own set of rules. Why did you choose these? What do they mean? Do they benefit a community, or just a select few people?

Once the 10 minutes is up, have students talk to their neighbor about what they wrote. Set a timer for 5 minutes.

3b. Next, bring the class together again to synthesize some collective thoughts for the remaining 15 minutes. Write this on the board, or in a document to save and refer to as a class. Here are some questions to ask the class:

- What came up in your conversations?
- What connections did you make between the rules in LWD, street code, and your own experiences?
- Why do we think rules like this exist? As a class, are we for or against them?
- How/why does revenge play into the rules?
- Do we see any discrepancies in Will’s masculinity-influenced rules and responses/thoughts from the girls and gender non-conformists in the classroom?
- Any final connections to LWD?

Assessment rubrics

*Today’s work is low-stakes formative work.

Journal Entry: (complete/incomplete)

- ☐ Entry is 5 sentences or more
- ☐ Entry addresses the prompt in some way or another
- ☐ Entry is in students own words

Street Code questions: (each question is x points)

- ☐ Student wrote in full meaningful sentences
- ☐ Answers show that they watched the video
- ☐ Answers show connections to the text/video
- ☐ Student answered in their own words

Rules/revenge freewrite (complete/incomplete)

- ☐ Student followed a prompt and gave thought to it
- ☐ Student wrote in full meaningful sentence
- ☐ Student wrote in their own words

Accessibility & Accommodation Options

*Assignments to be graded equitably, taking into account each students known abilities

ELLs & generalized accommodations

- Option to write in their [ELL's] own language for free-write and journal entry
- Option to audio/record journal entry in a quiet room
- Closed captions for their native language on Street Code video
- Written instructions for students to translate as needed
- Sentence starters and framers
- Working list of new/unique terms and phrases with definitions
- Assignments posted online with clear instructions, and copies of class notes so that students can complete at their own pace, and to make life easy for students who may not have been in class.

Wednesday: Written in Verse

Objectives: Short Term

- Student's will remember and understand the difference between prose and verse
- Students will apply their knowledge of prose and verse to the verse format in LWD
- Students will analyze forms of verse (poetry and song), and draw connections between the different texts of verse.
- Students will evaluate the different forms of verse and create responses that display their understanding.

Objectives: Long Term

- Students will expand upon their skills in analysis of verse
- Students will expand upon their skills in making textual connections
- Students will engage in joyful literacies by interacting with poetry and song
- Students will expand upon their intellect of how characteristics of verse portray their own meaning outside of words
- Students will expand upon their criticality of social justice issues through poetry and song.

Wednesday: Written in Verse

Materials - White board, dry erase markers - Projector - Copy of LWD - Links to respective content to be viewed and discussed in class - Headphones & laptops for students Time Allotments - Journal 10 mins - Verse vs prose lesson 10 min - Discussion of verse 20 min - Poetry and song assignments 40 min <i>*Monday was jam-packed, so today leaves some potential wiggle room. If students have extra time at the end, they can use it to work on anything that was not completed on monday.</i>	Learning Standards - 11-12R1: Cite strong and thorough textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly/implicitly and make logical inferences, including determining where the text is ambiguous; develop questions for deeper understanding and for further exploration. (RI&RL) - 11-12R4: Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in a text, including figurative and connotative meanings. Analyze the impact of specific word choices on meaning, tone, and mood, including words with multiple meanings. Analyze how an author uses and refines the meaning of technical or key term(s) over the course of a text. (RI&RL) - 11-12R7: In literary texts, analyze multiple adaptations of a source text as presented in different formats (e.g., works of art, graphic novels, ls, music, film, etc.), specifically evaluating how each version interprets the source. (RL) - 11-12W1c: Use precise language, content-specific vocabulary and literary techniques to express the appropriate complexity of the topic.
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Lesson Instruction

Phase 1. Journaling & reflecting.

As students arrive, guide them to begin their journaling for 10 minutes. Make sure the students are happy with their entry before moving on, this should not be a rushed activity.

Please respond to one of the prompts in the form of a paragraph (5 sentences or more).

**Because of today's creative format, you may not be able to do a traditional 5 sentence paragraph. That is fine—just do what you deem fit.* This is meant to be done in the style of a journal entry meaning: You DO NOT need to use formal, academic language! Say what comes to your mind the way YOU want to say it. I do not care if you use profanity, I do not care if you use slang or the type of wording you would use on a text message/social media comment. I do

not care if you don't address every question, the prompt is meant to get you thinking about the text. I do care to hear what you're thinking.

**Adopted from "The Elevated Educators BLM Journaling" (2020)*

PROMPT #1

Think of a song, poem, book/short story, or other piece of written/spoken art that really resonates with you. Why does it resonate with you, what is so special about it? Does it tackle any deep issues? If you can, find a quote from this piece that displays its power for you. If you'd like, do a quick analysis or describe what it means to you.

Available Idea Starters and Frames:

- A song/book/poem that means a lot to me is ____
- It means a lot to me because it is about ____
- When [author] says/writes ____, they are talking about ____

PROMPT #2

Write something from the perspective of a character in LWD. This can be lyrical, poetic, or written in prose, or you can use the speech bubble/narration box method used in graphic novels. You can rewrite a part of the story, like if Will's mom caught him. *Hint: try putting yourself in the position of the "ghosts" in the elevator. What would you say to a friend if they wanted to get revenge for you?*

Available Idea Starters and Frames:

- Write a diss-track on Briggs
- Write a eulogy for Shawn (a eulogy is a speech or piece of writing that talks about someone who just passed)
- If someone tried to get revenge for me, I would ____
- If I were to get revenge for someone, I would ____

Phase 2. Discussing verse in LWD.

2a. Quick mini lesson on verse **10 minutes**

Ideally, students know this. Still, it is important to make sure everyone is on the same page, especially ELLs.

For this, you can use a couple of slides to display the following information

Defining Verse

ASK: Who knows what the difference between verse and prose is?

- Prose is everyday writing.
- Verse is a poetic composition of writing.

ASK: What is an example of everyday writing?

- Everyday writing is what we use a lot in school. It uses full traditionally punctuated sentences and paragraphs.

ASK: What is a characteristic of poetic composition?

- Poetic composition is characterized by line breaks, meter, and rhyme (not exclusively)

So, our class definitions would be. . .

- Prose is the everyday writing we see in articles, books, and use to write essays and stories. It is characterized by its traditional use of sentences, paragraphs and accurate

grammar.

- Verse is the style of writing we see in song lyrics, poems, and sometimes longer poetically written stories. It is characterized by using line breaks, being read or performed rhythmically, and sometimes it rhymes or follows a specific meter.

ASK: Is LWD written in prose or verse?

- It is written in verse, and was originally unillustrated! It is considered “free form” because it doesn’t follow rhyming or meter rules, it essentially follows its own rules.

2b. Looking at excerpts. 20 minutes

Discussion of Excerpts

ASK: Why do we think the poetic format of LWD is so effective?

- Not looking for any particular response; just opening up the conversation

LOOK AT: Page 10(GN).



Discussion questions:

- Who wants to read this out loud? Try and read this based on how it visually appears on the page. **If multiple people want to give different readings ABSOLUTELY let them!*
- Someone read it this way too:

“I’ve never been in an earthquake. Don’t know if this was even close to how they are, but the ground definitely felt like it opened up and ate me.”

- What do we notice about the way it reads in its verse format versus written like prose?
- This short verse takes up a whole page. Why do we think that is?
- What is the feeling we get from the line breaks and even word breaks?
- What kind of concepts and emotions are being portrayed here without explicitly being stated? (What is this verse trying to tell us, what does it mean?)

How does this verse portray grief and trauma?

Check out page 14-15:



**See if you can get students to run the discussion on their own more here:*

- Who wants to read these verses?
- What do we think this verse is trying to express?
- What do we make of the metaphor of a “new moon” and “nothing down here is new”?
- What else do we notice?

Before ending this discussion, ask if anyone wants to share a page/verse they want to look at with the class.

Phase 3. Connecting song & poetry to LWD 40 minutes

Have students watch/listen/read “People Everyday” by Arrested Development

▶ Arrested Development - Everyday People (Official Video HD)(Audio HD)

Simultaneously, direct them to Genius Lyrics <https://genius.com/7252091> and show them how to use it (highlighted lines are annotated by fans and sometimes the artists with explanation and contextualizing facts).

Start by listening to the song as a class, and then look at some of the annotations as a class.

Next, students will work on their own to do the following assignment (on Google Classroom or whatever shared online space the class uses).

3a. Assignment 1 instructions:

1. After listening to “People Everyday” and exploring its annotations on Genius, find a section of LWD between pages 1-47 that you think relates to the song, or vice versa. Type out the verse(s) into a Google document, and pay attention to how the line breaks are used.
2. Make your own annotations using the “comments” tool. As you do this, try and make “translations” or “meanings” of parts of the verse. **For example, I might highlight the*

lines that say “nothing is ever new” on the verse from page 15 and note “Will says this to express that people in his neighborhood are always shot and killed, and nothing ever comes of it; no one snitches, and new people die. The cycle repeats itself”. Make at least 4 meaning-making annotations.

3. In addition to meaning-making of the verses, highlight parts of this/these verse(s) and explain your connection to “People Everyday”. Make at least two annotations with connections to the song.
4. Optional extra credit: If there is another piece of media that you want to make a connection to, please do! This can be a song, poem, or excerpt from a piece of writing.

***For ELLs:** Make an attempt to do these steps, but you may also/instead highlight phrases/words that are new to you and give an explanation of what it means.

3b. Assignment 2 instructions:

Gwendolyn Brooks is a 20th century African American Female author from Chicago. She wrote poetry that commented on violence in Black communities, especially the violent cycles young men caught themselves in.

Pick one of Gwendolyns poems provided here, read it, and write a few sentences about how it relates to LWD. Please find evidence to support your connections from your book and the poem.

***For ELLs:** Try to see if you can follow these instructions, but you may instead pick a passage from the novel and work on translating and annotating it the way we did for the first assignment.

Hints, tips, and notes:

- *poetry analysis can be daunting! I’m not looking for a right answer, I just want to see you try to make claims about the meaning, and connections to the text.*
- *Sometimes listening to the poem can be helpful, so feel free to look up readings on youtube, or from poetryfoundation.org*
- *Don’t be fooled by length; sometimes the “harder” ones are shorter.*
- *Don’t be afraid to ask for help!*

We Real Cool

By Gwendolyn Brooks

The Pool Players.
Seven at the Golden Shovels

We real cool. We
Left school. We

Lurk late. We
Strike straight. We

Sing sin. We
Thin gin. We

Jazz June. We
Die soon.

To the Young Who Want to Die

By Gwendolyn Brooks

Sit down. Inhale. Exhale.
The gun will wait. The lake will wait.
The tall gall in the small seductive vial
will wait will wait:
will wait a week; will wait through April.
You do not have to die this certain day.
Death will abide, will pamper your postponement.
I assure you death will wait. Death has
a lot of time. Death can
attend to you tomorrow. Or next week. Death is
just down the street; is most obliging neighbor;
can meet you any moment.

You need not die today.
Stay here--through pout or pain or peskyness.
Stay here. See what the news is going to be tomorrow.

Graves grow no green that you can use.
Remember, green's your color. You are Spring.

Young Afrikans

By Gwendolyn Brooks

of the furious

Who take Today and jerk it out of joint
have made new underpinnings and a Head.

Blacktime is time for chimeful
poemhood
but they decree a
jagged chiming now.

If there are flowers flowers
must come out to the road. Rowdy!—
knowing where wheels and people are,
knowing where whips and screams are,
knowing where deaths are, where the kind kills are.

As for that other kind of kindness,
if there is milk it must be mindful.
The milkofhumankindness must be mindful
as wily wines.
Must be fine fury.
Must be mega, must be main.

Taking Today (to jerk it out of joint)
the hardheroic maim the
leechlike-as-usual who use,
adhere to, carp, and harm.

And they await,
across the Changes and the spiraling dead,
our Black revival, our Black vinegar,
our hands, and our hot blood.

Assignment rubrics

Today is low-stakes formative work.

Journal Entry: (complete/incomplete)

- ☐ Entry is 5 sentences or more
- ☐ Entry addresses the prompt in some way or another
- ☐ Entry is in students own words

“People Everyday” assignment: each annotation is x points, 6 annotations total)

- ☐ At least 4 meaning-making annotations are made to the students chosen passage
- ☐ At least 2 song-connecting annotations are made
- ☐ Annotations show that thought was put into them
- ☐ Student answered in their own words
- ☐ Extra credit: student made a thoughtful outside connection

Gwendolyn Brooks assignment: (x points for a complete response to a poem)

- ☐ Student wrote a few meaningful full sentences
- ☐ Student drew on evidence from both the poem and the novel
- ☐ Student made an honest attempt to understand their chosen poem
- ☐ Student answered in their own words

Accessibility & Accommodation Options

*Assignments to be graded equitably, taking into account each students known abilities

ELLs & generalized accommodations

- Option to write in their [ELL’s] own language for free-write and journal entry
- Option to audio/record journal entry in a quiet room
- Sentence starters and framers
- Written instructions for students to translate as needed
- Working list of new/unique terms and phrases with definitions
- Assignments posted online with clear instructions, and copies of class notes so that students can complete at their own pace, and to make life easy for students who may not have been in class.
- ELLs have alternative options on each assignment for them to build language skills while deepening their understanding of the novel
- Closed captions on the “People Everyday” video, option to translate lyrics

Friday: Visual Literacies, Art as Social Justice

Objectives: Short Term

- Students will remember and

Objectives: Long Term

- Students will expand upon their

Friday: Visual Literacies, Art as Social Justice

understand practices for art critique - Students will apply said practices and conduct multiple art analysis' - Students will remember and understand vocabulary concerning elements of design - Students will apply said vocabulary when conducting critiques/analysis' - Students will analyze art relating to and illustrations in LWD - Students will evaluate their meaning and relevance - Students will create responses exercising these skills	<u>criticality</u>, skills and intellect through conducting practices of art literacy, and deepening their ability to identify important meanings/messages behind art - Students will engage in <u>joyful</u> literacies by interacting with art - Students will expand upon utilizing their <u>identity</u> to strengthen <u>skills</u> by interacting with art in contexts that are meaningful to them
Materials - White board, dry erase markers - Projector - Copy of LWD - Links to respective content to be viewed and discussed in class - Headphones & laptops for students - Printed out art pieces - Notebooks and pen/pencils Time Allotments - Journaling 10 mins - Gallery walk and discussion 30 mins - Solo work and responses 30 mins <i>*If there is not enough time to do everything, omit the last art exploration activity</i>	Learning Standards - 11-12R7: In literary texts, analyze multiple adaptations of a source text as presented in different formats (e.g., works of art, graphic novels, music, film, etc.), specifically evaluating how each version interprets the source. (RL) - 11-12W1c: Use precise language, content-specific vocabulary and literary techniques to express the appropriate complexity of the topic. - 11-12W4: Create a poem, story, play, artwork, or other response to a text, author, theme or personal experience; demonstrate knowledge and understanding of a variety of techniques and genres. - 11-12L6: Acquire and accurately use general academic and content-specific words and phrases, sufficient for reading, writing, speaking, and listening at the college and career readiness level; demonstrate independence in applying vocabulary knowledge when considering a word or phrase important to comprehension or expression.

Lesson Instruction

Phase 1. Journaling & reflecting.

As students arrive, guide them to begin their journaling for **10 minutes**. Make sure the students are happy with their entry before moving on, this should not be a rushed activity.

Please respond to one of the prompts in the form of a paragraph (5 sentences or more).

**Because of today's creative format, you may not be able to do a traditional 5 sentence paragraph. That is fine—just do what you deem fit.* This is meant to be done in the style of a journal entry meaning: You DO NOT need to use formal, academic language! Say what comes to your mind the way YOU want to say it. I do not care if you use profanity, I do not care if you use slang or the type of wording you would use on a text message/social media comment. I do not care if you don't address every question, the prompt is meant to get you thinking about the text. I do care to hear what you're thinking.

**Adopted from "The Elevated Educators BLM Journaling" (2020)*

PROMPT #1

Pick a page or frame from LWD that has little to no text. Some options include page 7, 9, 17, 20, 27, 30, 45. You may pick a page that has text on it too, but make sure it is visually rich. First, write down what visual aspect you first notice. Then, identify every visual aspect that you see; colors, saturation, negative space, art style, expressions, objects, anything at all. Lastly, pick one or more of the aspects you wrote down and try to determine what the purpose of it is. For example, does a prominent color represent something? Does a facial expression contradict the text?

Available Idea Starters and Frames:

- The first thing I noticed about this page was ____
- I noticed that this color appeared when ____
- I think the illustrator did ____ to show ____

PROMPT #2

Draw a frame, or two, or a whole page in the format of a graphic novel that illustrates something from your day. You can add or omit text bubbles, you hold all artistic license here. You can also draw something you'd add to LWD, or re-illustrate a scene from LWD. Be creative, have fun!

PROMPT #3

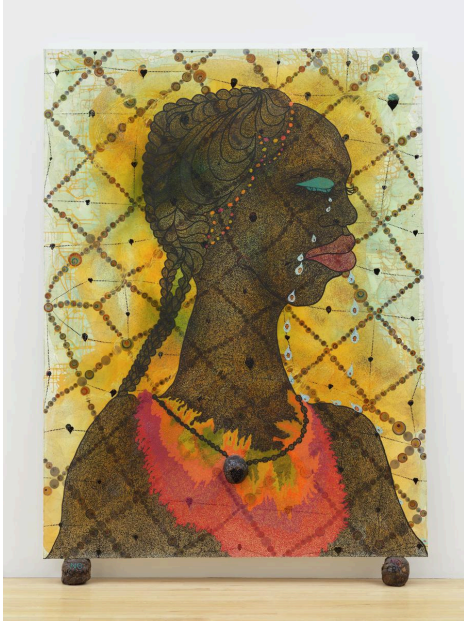
Take a look at Jason Reynolds original LWD, unillustrated. [Long Way Down - Plain Verse](#). Find one of the poems that is also in the graphic novel, and write about how the illustration affects the meaning. Does it change the meaning, or enhance it? Does the illustration cloud or clarify the text?

Available Idea Starters and Frames:

- The illustration changes/enhances the original verse by ____
- I prefer the original verse/illustrated verse because ____

Phase 2. Gallery walk and discussion on an art piece. **30 minutes**

2a. Print out and display the following 3 pieces of art around the classroom. Break students into 3 groups that rotate stations every 3 minutes, while they do a gallery walk for a total of 9 minutes with a notebook to take notes in. They are free to discuss what they notice with their peers.



“No Woman No Cry” by Chris Ofili 1998.



“The Duty of Disobedience” by Deborah Roberts 2019

“The Duty of



From the collection "Cry, Baby" by Devan

Shimoyama (2018)

After the 9 minutes are up, give them another 5 (quiet minutes) to go back to one of their favorite paintings and free write about it. Encourage them to make connections to themes in LWD.

2b. Once students have gathered back to their seats, you can begin a discussion. This should be pretty open ended, but make sure to touch on a few important things about each painting. Of course, make sure to be considering LWD throughout the discussion.

"No Woman, No Cry"

- Make sure the class noticed the children in her tears.

"The Duty of Disobedience"

- Discuss the meaning behind its title.

"Cry, Baby"

- Discuss the meaning behind this title.

All paintings:

- What is being depicted?
- What did we notice?
- What "jumped out"?
- What was more subtle?
- What kind of message or narrative can we pull from this?
- What kind of connections can we make to LWD?

General: touching on art as an act of social justice.

- Why do people make these kinds of paintings? Additionally, why do people write and illustrate stories like LWD?

Phase 3. Practicing art literacy. 30 minutes

Students will now go do solo work that looks and analyzes the visual aspects and illustrations of LWD. Provide students with these resources along with the working word bank and class notes that were introduced monday.

Graphic Novel/Comic Book Language: [comics in education](#)

Art Vocabulary: [MoMA Elements of Design](#)

**For ELLs, if there are things you'd like to express in your own language, especially when considering the emotional response to art, please feel free to do so.*

3a. Choose a full two-page sequence to observe and analyze. Ideally, this is a visually rich sequence. For example, pages 10-11 would be an excellent choice because of its full, saturated scenes. Make sure to absorb your sequence. Give yourself at least a few minutes to soak in all of the imagery and text. Consider every aspect of it, even the parts that seem less relevant.

1. Write about what you see. Consider the text and the illustrations simultaneously. What is being told, and what is shown?
2. How does the illustration change/affect the tone and mood? What kind of artistic techniques does the illustrator use to do so? Refer to the MoMA link for proper vocab.
3. How does this sequence make you feel? What emotions are sparked for you?
4. Choose a line or verse and connect it to a part of the illustration that displays the text and illustrations working together.

3b. Explore the internet and search for a piece of art that is relevant to your identity, one of your passions, or a social justice issue that is important to you. Here are some good resources:

[Open Source art: over 2 million pieces to explore](#)

[Black Artists from National Gallery of Art](#)

[Smithsonian Latinx Art Archive](#)

[National Museum of Women Artists](#)

[LGBTQ+ artist archive](#)

[Asian Art Archive \(this one also has a section on disability\)](#)

Once you've found a piece of art (or more), answer the following questions.

1. What is the title, author, and date of your piece?
2. What are some important parts of your artist's identity?
3. What is this piece about?
4. Why is this piece important to you?
5. Was there any information that contextualized this piece for you? (date, artist background, etc)

Assignment rubrics

Today is low-stakes formative work.

Journal Entry: (complete/incomplete)

- ☐ Entry is 5 sentences or more
- ☐ Entry addresses the prompt in some way or another
- ☐ Entry is in students own words

LWD sequence analysis: (x points per question)

- ☐ Student picked a full sequence to analyze
- ☐ Student used vocabulary provided in the resources
- ☐ Student wrote in full meaningful sentences
- ☐ Student wrote in their own words

Art Exploration: (x points per question)

- ☐ Student put thought into their chosen piece
- ☐ Student found and cited the relevant info (title, author, date)
- ☐ Student found a piece of relevant background information (race, mission, gender, etc)
- ☐ Student wrote in full meaningful sentences
- ☐ Student wrote in their own words

Accessibility & Accommodation Options

*Assignments to be graded equitably, taking into account each students known abilities

ELLs & generalized accommodations

- Option to write in their [ELLs] own language for free-write, and journal entry
- Option to audio/record journal entry in a quiet room
- Sentence starters and framers
- Written instructions for students to translate as needed
- Working list of new/unique terms and phrases with definitions
- Assignments posted online with clear instructions, and copies of class notes so that students can complete at their own pace, and to make life easy for students who may not have been in class.
- Option for [ELLs] to hybridize language when writing their answers for the art analysis

Sample Assignment - Wednesday Assignments

PROMPT #2

Write something from the perspective of a character in LWD. This can be lyrical, poetic, or written in prose, or you can use the speech bubble/narration box method used in graphic novels. You can rewrite a part of the story, like if Will's mom caught him. *Hint: try putting yourself in the position of the "ghosts" in the elevator. What would you say to a friend if they wanted to get revenge for you?*

Available Idea Starters and Frames:

- Write a diss-track on briggs
- Write a eulogy for Shawn (a eulogy is a speech or piece of writing that talks about someone who just passed)
- If someone tried to get revenge for me, I would ____
- If I were to get revenge for someone, I would ____

Journal Entry: If my brother decided he wanted to get revenge for me after being killed, I would ride down the elevator with him as a ghost, like in the book. I would probably tell him that if he killed the person who killed me, I wouldn't feel any better, I'd just feel worse because

my brother is miserable and in jail or worse, dead. I'd tell him that mom and dad would be pissed at him. I'd tell him that he would be adding to a never ending cycle. I'd tell him he would be no better than the person who killed me. My brother is a musician so maybe I'd encourage him to write a song about his pain instead of killing. I'd also tell him that I would be too scared to get revenge for him, so why would he want to get revenge for me if I'm a bad sister? Even though this is what I think I'd say, maybe ghost me would be so mad that she would allow my brother to avenge me (us?). I can't relate to Shawn's experience, so I wouldn't know until I was in his survival mode.

3a. Assignment 1 instructions:

5. After listening to "People Everyday" and exploring its annotations on Genius, find a section of LWD between pages 1-47 that you think relates to the song, or vice versa. Type out the verse(s) into a Google document, and pay attention to how the line breaks are used.
6. Make your own annotations using the "comments" tool. As you do this, try and make "translations" or "meanings" of parts of the verse. **For example, I might highlight the lines that say "nothing is ever new" on the verse from page 15 and note "Will says this to express that people in his neighborhood are always shot and killed, and nothing ever comes of it; no one snitches, and new people die. The cycle repeats itself".* Make at least 4 meaning-making annotations.
7. In addition to meaning-making of the verses, highlight parts of this/these verse(s) and explain your connection to "People Everyday". Make at least two annotations with connections to the song.
8. Optional extra credit: If there is another piece of media that you want to make a connection to, please do! This can be a song, poem, or excerpt from a piece of writing.

When bad things happen,
We can usually look up and see
The moon, big and bright,
Shining over us.

But when Shawn
Died,
The moon was off.

Somebody told me once a month
The moon blacks out
And becomes new,

I'll tell you one thing,
The moon is lucky it's not down here
Where nothing
Is ever
New.

Page 14-15

3b. Assignment 2 instructions:

Gwendolyn Brooks is a 20th century African American Female author from Chicago. She wrote poetry that commented on violence in Black communities, especially the violent cycles young

men caught themselves in.

Pick one of Gwendolyn's poems provided here, read it, and write a few sentences about how it relates to LWD. Please find evidence to support your connections from your book and the poem.

Young Afrikans

By Gwendolyn Brooks

of the furious

Who take Today and jerk it out of joint
have made new underpinnings and a Head.

Blacktime is time for chimeful
poemhood
but they decree a
jagged chiming now.

If there are flowers flowers
must come out to the road. Rowdy!—
knowing where wheels and people are,
knowing where whips and screams are,
knowing where deaths are, where the kind kills are.

As for that other kind of kindness,
if there is milk it must be mindful.
The milk of humankindness must be mindful
as wily wines.
Must be fine fury.
Must be mega, must be main.

Taking Today (to jerk it out of joint)
the hardheroic maim the
leechlike-as-usual who use,
adhere to, carp, and harm.

And they await,
across the Changes and the spiraling dead,
our Black revival, our Black vinegar,
our hands, and our hot blood.

With help from the title, I think that this poem is about young Black people having poetry and artistry in their souls, but the outlet becomes violent. The second stanza expresses that blackness is poetic, but the poetry that is released is “jagged”. The young Black kids are corrupt by the knowledge of violence, (knowing where. . .) they are burdened by knowing, and pulled into corruption.

This poem is related to LWD, because LWD expresses a lot of love, positivity, and community about being a young Black man in a Black neighborhood, but also expresses the darkness of knowing. Will knows a lot about the darkness in his community, even though he has not yet

engaged in it. On page 15, he immediately references the rules and plans to kill Briggs the very next day; he is not even allowed to mourn.

Reflection

As I tackled this project, I considered everything that I'd been absorbing this year. Starting with RCSD, and the learning community as I experienced it. Along with this class, and Muhammads framework, I also was thinking about Race, Class, Gender, and Disability, as taught by Dr. Joanne Larson. I kept in mind Literacy in American Education, as taught by Dardan Shabani. Lastly, I thought about my experience shadowing James Flagler at East High School and how he took his students seriously, never trying to infantilize them or pretend they weren't personally experiencing truly unfair and brutal stuff for their age. So, what I came up with was a sort of mental word cloud; graphic novels, accessibility, ELLs, social justice, violence, Black identities, taking the student seriously, and the cherry on top, joy. To me, most of these things spark joy, and that is because a lot of these words/phrases were identity markers. However, I recognized that the joy aspect of this word cloud would be dictated by whether or not the social justice aspect was appropriately considered and used. I knew fairly early on that *Long Way Down* by Jason Reynolds and illustrated by Danika Novgordoff was what I wanted to use for my mini unit. I started noticing very quickly while subbing at RCSD that students were not reading full novels, and that the students were primarily black, brown, and below the poverty line. I noticed that many of the students' realities didn't look much different than the lives displayed in LWD. Being inspired by my classes, mentors, and subbing experiences, I realized that what was important to me was creating a unit that addressed the dark reality for many young Black people in America, while having students engage in literacies that help them break that down and fight it.

One of the primary challenges I faced was keeping in mind Muhammads key point, that joy is not possible without justice. My unit is attempting to address both at once. Part of this made it so that I was trying not to put a bunch of grim content within the lessons, but also keeping it real. I believe I successfully combated making a triggering and oppressive unit by

making a majority of the content we deal with have some artistic value to it. For example, Wednesday and Friday are centered around the creative mediums displayed in the novel, visual and written art. I decided that Monday, which is probably the toughest day for facing traumatic social justice issues, would be best at the beginning rather than the end. This way, the students are first addressing why the book is important as a pillar of social justice, and then they work towards building upon literacies and joy to address the darkness with strength and knowledge.

On Monday, I felt that the students would most strongly engage in criticality, intellect, identity, and touch on joy. I think it was important for the first day to strongly address criticality and identity because it sets the tone for the unit and gives students a sort of anchor to consider the text through. I felt that the video I assigned for Monday was very essential in the criticality aspect because it addresses some of the roots of the violent cycles we talk about throughout the week. I also feel that the identity work done that day makes the “mirror, window and sliding glass” door concept more apparent. Students are able to gauge the way they interact with this text by deciding subconsciously whether it's a mirror, window, or sliding glass door. This left a lot of room for joy and skills to be addressed Wednesday and Friday, as students are able to build upon their literacies while being anchored in viewing everything through that critical lens. Intellect, criticality, and identity is always being built upon alongside skills and joy. This pattern is going to be how I address many of my lessons and units from now on. I think it is super beneficial to start everything with strong ties to criticality. This is rooted in the idea that without social justice there isn't joy, so I will always be giving the tone that the literacies students are building upon are to be used as a tool to reach joy. One of the parts I'm most proud of about this unit is that I tried to make it so that any student, present or not, could accomplish the goals and assignments of this unit. The idea is that everything, including notes, are posted on something like Google Classroom with accessible instructions. The equitable aspect of this unit is based on the assignments and the anchor text all being very versatile, meaning there is an option for every student at every skill level. I love that my anchor text is a graphic novel, as I just wrote my final

essay for Language and Literacy in American Education on the versatility of graphic novels as a tool to level the playing field for diverse learners. I'm also very grateful for learning about Joyful literacy pursuits, because it helps me stay mindful about making my lessons something that students can feel good about, not just complete out of necessity.